

Information Cards — The Boudica Pact

I1-I22 · Print double-sided · Cut along borders · Hand player-facing front to agents on discovery

SUPPORTING INTEL

I1

The Epicenter

The Covenant Wayfinder station has confirmed: the anomalous Corruption signature is centered on a farm in rural Staffordshire. The signature is consistent with a breached supernatural binding — estimated age 1,900+ years. The pattern suggests a single-point containment failure: something was held in place by something else, and the "something else" has been removed. The signature is strengthening at a rate consistent with an entity approaching wakefulness. Soil samples from the epicenter show gold particulate and a mineral signature not native to the region.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L1 (Dunn's Farm), HQ initial briefing

HQ Fallback: Day 6

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This is the first card agents receive — it confirms they're in the right place. The epicenter is the binding locus. Everything flows from here.

The Hole

In the north field of Dunn's farm, a narrow hole — approximately 2 cm in diameter, 1.2 meters deep — pierces the soil. The edges are fresh, consistent with a plough strike within the last 2-3 weeks. Soil analysis reveals gold residue lining the hole walls and trace elements consistent with 1st-century CE Roman smelting techniques underneath 7th-century Anglo-Saxon metallurgy. Something was buried here in two phases — Roman gold first, Anglo-Saxon gold on top. The Anglo-Saxon layer included a single coin, now missing. The plough pulled it up. The hole is warmer than the surrounding soil (34°C vs. ambient 12°C).

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L1 (Dunn's Farm — soil analysis of the binding locus hole)

HQ Fallback: Day 6

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: Tech Diff 1 confirms the gold residue and the two-phase deposition. The temperature differential is inexplicable by conventional science — the agents should notice this.

Arthur's Find

According to regulars at the Plough and Furrow, Arthur Dunn came into the pub three weeks ago, bought a round for everyone, and was "not himself — excited, but trying not to show it." He showed several people something small and gold he'd found in his north field. He wouldn't say exactly where. He wouldn't let anyone hold it for more than a moment. "Saxon-looking," said one regular. "Warm," said another. "He said he was going to have it looked at." He never did. He left for a fishing trip to Scotland the next morning. He hasn't been back. No one has heard from him.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L2 (The Plough and Furrow), NPC1 (townsfolk)

HQ Fallback: Day 6

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: The "warm" detail is consistent — the keystone coin maintains body temperature regardless of ambient conditions. Arthur didn't get it appraised. He got scared. Or the coin didn't let him.

The Pub Bet

Behind the bar at the Plough and Furrow, a betting pool is pinned to the wall: "What Arthur Found." Entries include: "Roman hoard" (£5), "Saxon burial goods" (£10), "unexploded bomb" (£2), "a single coin" (£3), "absolutely nothing and he's having us on" (£15), and — in Mrs. Albright's handwriting — "something that should have stayed buried" (£1). The pot is £47. No one can agree on what Arthur showed them because Arthur showed different people different things at different times — a coin one night, "something interesting" another night, nothing at all on his last visit. The contradictions are in Arthur's storytelling, not the townsfolk's memories.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L2 (The Plough and Furrow), NPC1

HQ Fallback: Day 5

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: The bet is a nice bit of colour but it's also a clue — Arthur was inconsistent because he was conflicted. Part of him wanted to tell people. Part of him — or the coin — wanted to keep the secret. Mrs. Albright's £1 entry is the closest to the truth.

Arthur's Habits

Arthur Dunn is — was — a creature of habit. Thursday nights at the pub. Fishing trip to Scotland every June, same lodge, same week, for 15 years. He never missed a Thursday. He never changed the fishing trip. This year, he left for Scotland two months early, told no one at the lodge he was coming, stayed two nights, and left abruptly. The lodge owner said he seemed "distracted — kept looking over his shoulder, kept touching his coat pocket." He paid in cash and drove off toward the English border. He hasn't been seen since. His post is piling up. His cottage is locked. His truck is gone.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L2 (pub regulars), NPC1 (townsfolk), O4M1 (fishing lodge)

HQ Fallback: Day 5

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: The fishing trip is the key to O4 (The Farmer's Trail). The lodge in Scotland is the last confirmed sighting. Dunn is not hiding — he's moving, aimlessly, pulled by something he doesn't understand.

The Staffordshire Hoard

The Staffordshire Hoard — 3,500 pieces of Anglo-Saxon gold and garnet, discovered in 1984 in a field less than 2 miles from Dunn's farm — is held at the Birmingham Museum and Art Gallery. The hoard is the largest collection of Anglo-Saxon gold ever found. Six of seven "key coins" — coins with unusual iconography, identified as a distinct sub-group within the hoard — were recovered and catalogued. The seventh, designated "Unrecovered Item #7" in the dig records, was documented as "likely displaced below excavation depth." The excavation reached 1.0 meter. The coin was at 1.2 meters. The archaeologists missed it by 20 centimetres.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L3 (Birmingham Museum), NPC2 (Dr. Price)

HQ Fallback: Day 6

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: The "seven key coins" are the binding's original Anglo-Saxon currency. Six are in the museum. The seventh — the keystone — was in the ground until Arthur Dunn's plough found it. Any of the six museum coins will work for the re-burial. The pact doesn't specify which coin. It specifies gold.

The Red Woman

Local folklore in the Staffordshire villages speaks of "the Red Woman" — a figure in a red dress seen at the edge of fields before bad harvests, before livestock deaths, before things go wrong. The story predates the village — versions appear in 17th-century parish records, in a 12th-century boundary charter, and in Eadwine's 8th-century chronicle under a different name: "the queen who would not leave." Mrs. Albright, a pub regular, has been dreaming of a woman in red standing at the edge of her property for two weeks. "She doesn't move. She just watches. And I wake up feeling like I've lost something I can't name."

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L1 (local records at the farm), L2 (pub regulars, especially Mrs. Albright), NPC1

HQ Fallback: Day 5

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: The "Red Woman" is the entity wearing Boudica's shape. The folklore is fragmented cultural memory of the blight's previous active periods — 1st century CE, 7th century, and now. Mrs. Albright's dreams are not cheese-related.

The Anomalous Coin

Dr. Helen Price, curator at the Birmingham Museum, has been searching for "Unrecovered Item #7" since the dig ended. The dig records describe a coin with anomalous iconography — a woman's face on the obverse that doesn't match any known Anglo-Saxon die, a heptagonal (seven-pointed) pattern on the reverse with no known parallel. The metal composition noted in the preliminary scan was "gold, with trace elements inconsistent with known Anglo-Saxon sources." Dr. Price believes the coin was stolen by a dig volunteer. She's wrong. The coin was 20 cm below the deepest point of the excavation. She doesn't know a farmer found it three weeks ago.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L3 (Birmingham Museum — Dr. Price's office files), NPC2 (Dr. Price), NPC5 (Dr. Rhys — corroborating dig records)

HQ Fallback: Day 5

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: The heptagonal pattern is unique — seven points. Not Anglo-Saxon. Not Roman. Possibly pre-Celtic. The entity was already old when the Romans encountered it. The symbol may be its "name" — a shape it recognizes.

Shifted Displays

Dr. Price has noticed that items in the Anglo-Saxon gallery have shifted overnight — a few millimetres, but consistently. All the hoard coins in the display case have moved toward the north side of their mounts. Toward Staffordshire. She attributes this to cleaning staff bumping the cases. She has increased security — additional patrol checks, a review of display case locks. This has made public-gallery access slightly harder (+1 Difficulty on Sneak rolls in the gallery). The coins are responding to the binding's weakening. They're trying to go home.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L3 (Birmingham Museum — after OLM1), NPC2 (Dr. Price)

HQ Fallback: Day 4

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This is the museum's first sign that something is wrong. Price rationalizes it. The agents should not. The coins are gold from the original pact — they know where they belong.

Eadwine's Chronicle

An 8th-century vellum codex in the British Library, catalogued as "Chronicle of the Abbey of St. Chad, Mercia." The monk Eadwine records, in a Mercian minuscule hand, the reinforcement of a supernatural binding in the Staffordshire countryside. He describes "the iron-men" (Romans) who "made a bargain with the queen who would not leave, placing gold in the earth that she could not consume." The binding held for 500 years. By Eadwine's time, the gold was "growing thin" — not corroding, but losing its hold. The Mercian king authorized additional gold to be buried — the Staffordshire Hoard. Eadwine was present. He recorded the ritual. He also recorded complaints about the food, the weather, and his abbot.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L4 (British Library — Eadwine's chronicle)

HQ Fallback: Day 5

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This is the central research document. It connects the binding to the Romans, the Staffordshire Hoard to the binding, and provides the binding words (I16) and the reference to the Roman ledger (I11). Lore or Investigate Diff 2 extracts all relevant information.

The Book of Reckonings

In the margins of his chronicle, Eadwine references "the book of reckonings in the iron-men's city of stone" — a Roman ledger that recorded the original pact. "The iron-men wrote everything down," Eadwine notes. "They did not understand what they were writing, but they wrote it." The "city of stone" is Rome. The "book of reckonings" is Codex Mercaturae Britanniae — a trade ledger mis-catalogued in the Vatican Apostolic Archive. Eadwine never saw it himself, but his abbot had heard of it from a pilgrim. The ledger contains the original pact terms.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L4 (British Library — Eadwine's marginalia), L5 (Vatican Archive — confirmed by Father Matteo), NPC4

HQ Fallback: Day 4

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This is the thread that pulls agents to Rome. Without this reference, the Vatican ledger is unfindable — it's mis-catalogued under "medieval merchant accounts." Eadwine's chronicle is the only document that connects it to the binding.

The Roman Ledger

Codex Mercaturae Britanniae — a thin codex of 12 folios, bound in worn leather, held in Section XVII of the Vatican Apostolic Archive. The handwriting is imperial bureaucratic minuscule — neat, precise, utterly without affect. The entry for the binding reads: "Item: one binding, site CXVII, province of Britannia. Authorized by governor Gnaeus Julius Agricola, third year of his office. Payment: gold, measured by weight. Condition: gold in earth, binding holds. Gold removed, subject returns. Gold returned, binding restored. Note: quantity not specified — a single aureus deemed sufficient per consultation with [name redacted], priest of the [syncretic] cult. Expense classified as exceptional. No further disbursement anticipated." The Romans filed a supernatural pact as an expense report.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L5 (Vatican Archive — after O2M2), NPC4 (Father Matteo)

HQ Fallback: Day 3

Type: Supporting Intel (but essential to CT-1 and CT-3)

Notes: The ledger is the key to the resolution. It confirms: (1) gold in earth = binding holds, (2) no quantity specified — a single coin works, (3) any gold from the original pact is valid. The "consultation with [name redacted]" suggests the Romans didn't design the binding — they hired a specialist. The unnamed priest of the syncretic cult knew what they were dealing with.

The Terms

The binding's terms, as recorded in the Roman ledger and corroborated by Eadwine's chronicle, are elegantly simple: gold placed in the earth at the binding locus sustains a pact that keeps the entity dormant. Gold removed weakens the binding. Gold returned restores it. The pact specifies "gold, measured by weight" — no quantity, no specific coin, no ritual beyond placement and words. The Romans were precise about loopholes. A single coin, any coin from the original Roman or Anglo-Saxon deposits, is sufficient. The words must be spoken — in Latin or Old English, either works. The entity does not care about language. It cares about the assertion: the debt is paid, the gold is placed, the binding holds.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L5 (Vatican Archive — after O2M2), L4 (Eadwine's chronicle — corroboration), NPC4

HQ Fallback: Day 3

Type: Supporting Intel (but essential to resolution)

Notes: This card should be given to agents when they have both the ledger and the chronicle — it synthesizes the binding's mechanics. This tells them exactly what they need to do: get a coin, go to the locus, speak the words. The rest is execution.

The Anomaly Report

Dr. Margaret Rhys, the archaeologist who led the 1984 Staffordshire Hoard excavation, filed an anomaly report for a coin detected by ground-penetrating radar at a depth of 1.2 meters — below the main hoard deposit at 0.8-1.0 meters. The radar signature was "consistent with a single gold object, approximately 2 cm diameter." The dig budget ran out before the deeper object could be recovered. Dr. Rhys noted in her report: "Anomalous object at 120 cm — likely displaced from main deposit by plough action over centuries, or deliberately placed deeper. Recommend recovery in next season." There was no next season. The funding was not renewed. Dr. Rhys retired. The coin stayed in the ground — until Arthur Dunn's plough found it three years later.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L6 (Dr. Rhys's cottage — dig records), NPC5 (Dr. Rhys)

HQ Fallback: Day 4

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This confirms the keystone coin was detected but not recovered. The 20 cm gap between the main hoard and the keystone is significant — the Anglo-Saxons placed the keystone deeper, at the exact center of the binding, separate from the rest of the gold.

Okonkwo's Testimony

Mr. Samuel Okonkwo, night security guard at the Birmingham Museum for 15 years, reports that the coins in the Anglo-Saxon gallery have begun glowing — a faint reddish warmth, visible only in peripheral vision. The glow began approximately three weeks ago. It has been intensifying. Additionally, the coins shift position overnight — a millimetre at a time, but consistently toward the north wall of the gallery. Toward Staffordshire. Mr. Okonkwo filed a report with his supervisor, who dismissed it as "reflection from the exit sign." It's not a reflection. Mr. Okonkwo will talk to anyone who takes him seriously. He knows the patrol schedules. He knows the vault code rotation. He knows when the security camera feeds loop.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L3 (Birmingham Museum — after O1M2), NPC3 (Mr. Okonkwo)

HQ Fallback: Day 2

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: Okonkwo is the key to the museum infiltration. His testimony confirms the coins are responding to the binding's failure. The northward movement — toward Staffordshire — is the coins trying to return to the locus.

Eadwine's Marginalia

Between complaints about the abbey's food ("the pottage is thinner than the abbot's mercy") and observations about the weather ("rain without end, as though the sky itself weeps for our sins, which are numerous"), Eadwine recorded the binding words in Old English, with a Latin gloss in the margin. The words, translated: "The debt is paid. The gold is placed. The binding holds. That which was taken is returned. That which would take is denied. By the weight of the gold and the word of the king, let the earth keep what the earth keeps. Let the sleeper sleep." The Latin version in the Roman ledger is terser: "Aurum in terra. Pactum tenet. Quod ablatum est, redditur. Quod auferre vult, negatur." ("Gold in earth. The pact holds. What was taken is returned. What would take is denied.") Either version works. The entity does not care about language.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L4 (British Library — Eadwine's chronicle, marginalia), L5 (Vatican Archive — Roman ledger corroboration)

HQ Fallback: Day 4

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This is the script for the re-burial ritual. The agents need these words. Without them, the coin will be rejected (Fracture condition). The Latin is shorter; the Old English is more poetic. Either works. An agent must speak the words aloud at the binding locus during the ritual.

Quarantine

The British Ministry of Agriculture has declared an "Agricultural Health Zone" in a 5-mile radius around Dunn's farm. Roadblocks have appeared on county roads — Ministry officials in green Land Rovers, checking identifications, asking about "unusual crop conditions" and "insect activity." The official explanation is "soil-borne pathogen investigation." The real explanation is that the Ministry doesn't know what's happening and is containing first, asking questions later. Mr. Philip Croft, a senior agricultural inspector, is leading the investigation. He knows the official explanation doesn't match the evidence. Movement within the quarantine zone is restricted — agents must use Covenant credentials (Manipulate Diff 1), stealth (Sneak Diff 2), or alternative routes.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: O3M1 trigger, L1 (after activation), NPC7 (Mr. Croft)

HQ Fallback: Day 3

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: The quarantine is a complication, not a roadblock. It makes movement harder but doesn't prevent it. Croft is reachable — he's confused and open to explanations that make more sense than his own.

Dunn Found

Arthur Dunn has been located at a motel near Lichfield, 20 miles from his farm. He's been there for three days. He hasn't slept more than an hour at a time. He keeps touching his coat pocket — the pocket where the coin was. "I can still feel it," he says. "It's not in my pocket anymore. I threw it in a river in Scotland. But I can still feel it. It's warm. It's always warm." He claims he threw the coin into a river in the Scottish Highlands — an act of desperation after two weeks of being unable to return home. "I thought if I got rid of it, I could go back. But I still can't go back. And I can still feel it." The coin is unrecoverable — it's in a river somewhere in Scotland. The agents confirm they need a museum coin for the re-burial.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: O4M2 trigger, NPC6 (Arthur Dunn)

HQ Fallback: Day 2

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: Dunn is found, but his coin is gone. The river coin is a narrative dead end — the agents cannot recover it in time. This forces the museum route. Dunn can provide emotional weight: he's not a villain, he's a victim of his own plough. He didn't know. He still doesn't fully understand. He just wants to sleep.

The Dig Coordinates

Dr. Margaret Rhys's excavation records include precise grid coordinates for the anomalous coin's radar return: Grid Reference SK 10203 07214 — the north field of what is now Arthur Dunn's farm, approximately 15 meters from the field boundary hedgerow, at a depth of 1.2 meters. These coordinates match the binding locus precisely. The hole Arthur's plough left is within 2 meters of the grid reference. The main hoard deposit — the 3,500 pieces now in the Birmingham Museum — was located 40 meters to the southwest. The Anglo-Saxons buried the bulk of the gold away from the keystone, probably to avoid disturbing it. The keystone was the anchor. The rest was reinforcement.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L6 (Dr. Rhys's cottage — dig grid maps), NPC5

HQ Fallback: Day 4

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: These coordinates confirm the binding locus location beyond doubt. If agents haven't found the hole yet, these coordinates lead them directly to it. The 40-meter separation between hoard and keystone is archaeologically unusual — it supports the interpretation that the burial was ritual, not practical.

Quarantine Expands

The Ministry of Agriculture has expanded the Agricultural Health Zone. The quarantine now covers a 12-mile radius around Dunn's farm, encompassing several villages and reaching the outskirts of Birmingham. Roadblocks have multiplied. Checkpoints are staffed by officials who are increasingly nervous — the "soil-borne pathogen" explanation is wearing thin, and the officials on the ground know it. Birmingham is on alert. The museum has increased security further — additional guards, more frequent patrols, a review of all access protocols. Museum infiltration is now Hard difficulty (+1 additional Difficulty on all Sneak and Tech rolls). The re-burial site (L7) is deep inside the quarantine zone — agents must cross at least two checkpoints to reach it, requiring Sneak (Diff 3) or a convincing cover story (Manipulate Diff 2).

DA REFERENCE

Sources: O3M2 trigger, NPC7 (Mr. Croft)

HQ Fallback: Day 1

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This is the late-game complication. The world is noticing. The agents are running out of time and space. The quarantine makes everything harder but also provides cover — no one questions people moving through a crisis zone if they look like they belong.

The Ledger's Provenance

The Roman ledger — Codex Mercaturae Britanniae — bears the official stamp of Gnaeus Julius Agricola's office, dated 78 CE. It is countersigned by an unnamed priest described only as "priest of the [syncretic] cult" — the word "syncretic" is in the original Latin. The priest's name has been deliberately scratched from the document — not torn, not erased, but carefully removed with a blade, leaving a rectangular hole in the vellum. Someone wanted this priest forgotten. Father Matteo notes that the handwriting of the removal is 4th-century — Christian, after the Empire's conversion. "The early Church was systematic about erasing pagan practitioners from official records. But they kept the ledger. They knew it was important. They just didn't want anyone to know who wrote it." The pact was a hybrid — Celtic earth-rites combined with Roman contract-law. A negotiation between two systems of understanding the world, designed to contain something neither could destroy.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: L5 (Vatican Archive — after O2M2), NPC4 (Father Matteo's analysis)

HQ Fallback: Day 3

Type: Supporting Intel

Notes: This card adds depth to the pact's origin. The unnamed priest is a ghost in the story — someone who understood both Celtic earth-rites and Roman bureaucracy well enough to design a binding that has lasted 1,900 years. The agents will never know their name. The early Church made sure of that.

What This Has Always Been About

After Boudica's defeat in 61 CE, her dying curse — her rage at what was taken from her — was adopted by something older than the Celts: a presence in the earth that had no name, no form, no voice until she gave it one. The Romans couldn't destroy it. They bargained: gold in the earth, the curse sleeps. The Anglo-Saxons reinforced the bargain 500 years later with the Staffordshire Hoard. A monk named Eadwine recorded it between complaints about the food. A farmer named Arthur Dunn broke it by accident in 1987. The entity is not evil. It is incompatible. It wants the land back — not to rule, but to return to a state before human presence. The binding holds as long as gold stays in the earth. The agents must put it back. A single coin. The right words. The right place. The door closes. The sleeper sleeps. For now.

DA REFERENCE

Sources: All. This is the synthesis card — given to agents when they have assembled the full picture, typically at L7 or during the re-burial ritual.

HQ Fallback: N/A — cannot be provided by HQ. Must be assembled by agents.

Type: Containment Truth (synthesis of CT-1, CT-2, CT-3)

Notes: This card represents the moment the agents understand the case completely. Award it at the climax or during the Aftermath debrief. It is the answer to "what was this really about?" The entity will need binding again in 300–500 years. The Covenant should file a standing order. The Anglo-Saxons understood the cycle. Now the Covenant does too.